

Life on Base

The comfort and stability of permanent bases stood in stark contrast to the horrors and deprivations of combat. Similar to small towns, the larger bases were slices of Middle America in the jungles of Vietnam.

◀◀ BEFORE

The construction boom in South Vietnam was unprecedented in American military history.

MOVING CAMPS

Previous foreign wars had emphasized **troop mobility** rather than long-term occupation, and conflicts simply did not last long enough to result in sophisticated construction projects. Vietnam was different. Even before the **commitment of US ground troops** escalated the war, the US had built large bases to house troops and provide support to the air and ground wars.

Over the course of the war, the United States built hundreds of bases across South Vietnam. Some were rugged outposts perched on mountaintops or hidden deep in the jungle, while others were just as well developed as any stateside base. One—Long Binh Post—was so large that it had a commuter bus service. All of these bases supported the US war effort, but the contrasts between the different types led to disparate experiences for the Americans who lived on them. Between soldiers in makeshift camps eating C-rations, and men in catered brick mess halls, there could be no one typical experience of life in Vietnam.

Building infrastructure

Constructing the US base network took time and money. Navy construction battalions and troop labor built some of the military infrastructure, but private American construction firms employing Vietnamese workers were responsible for most of it. Collectively, they built more than 100 airfields, permanent billets for 350,000 troops, and hospitals with 8,000 beds to treat the wounded.

In order to ensure that life for US soldiers was as comfortable as the tactical situation would allow, and that every corner of the war effort was properly supplied, they also built seven deep-draft ports, storage for three billion barrels of oil, 600 miles (966 km) of roads, and 5 miles (8 km) of bridges. Some 56 million square feet of storage areas were built, as well as cold storage—which facilitated fresh food for 90 percent of the meals served to American troops during the war.